

Who Should Get Help? Moral Norms for Partiality are Influenced by Relationship Expectations

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The case for impartiality

“Impartiality demands that when I sit up all night with my sick child, I must ask whether my time and care could be better spent on a **stranger in greater need**. It requires me to treat the fact that this is *my* child as **morally irrelevant**.”

- Cottingham, 1986

Impartial beneficence in practice

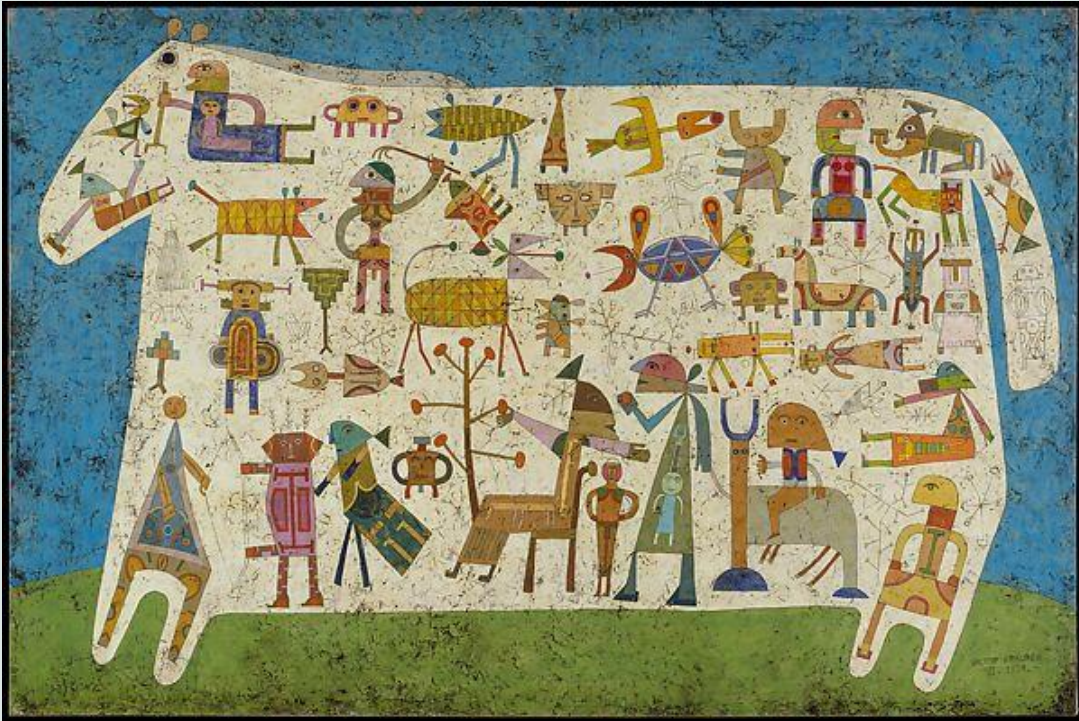
We value fairness, equal treatment, and punish nepotism and favouritism

But do people actually view impartiality as the morally right thing to do?



The Good Samaritan. Vincent van Gogh (1890)

Why do we have morality?



Prelude to a Civilization. Victor Brauner (1954)

Cooperation relationships are essential for human flourishing

Moral norms – shared rules about what's acceptable, expected, and obligatory in reciprocal relationships

Good cooperation partners are trustworthy and predictable

Moral norms are context dependent

What counts as “moral” depends on the context of relationship

In communal sharing relationships like family, partiality or preferential treatment of those within the group is an obligation



Gobustan petroglyphs, UNESCO World Heritage Site (5,000 to 8,000 BCE).
Azerbaijan

Should a moral person prioritize those closest to them?



Feeding The Young. Jean-Francois Millet (1850)

A moral norm for partiality in close relationships – people consistently give more (e.g. kidneys, money, favours) to close others

Are third-party moral evaluations of others influenced by the partiality norms in close relationships?

- Are partial actors seen as fulfilling their relationships obligations?
- Are partial actors seen as predictable cooperation partners?

Experiment 1



N = 901 (MTurk sample)

- 52% female
- $M_{age} = 39.25$

Relationship closeness as between-subject manipulation:



Neighbour



Close friend



Cousin

Michael was scrolling through Facebook during a work break. Right before he closed the app, he saw two similar posts that were shared by a friend in which people were using “Go Fund Me” to ask for donations to help pay for flood damage to their homes after a strong thunderstorm. **He did not recognize one of the people; he was a stranger. However, he did recognize the other person; he was one of Michael's close friends.**

Impartial actor helps:



Stranger

Michael decided not to donate money to his close friend, but instead **donated \$100 to the stranger** to help with the cost of their home's damage.

Partial actor helps:



Close other

Michael decided not to donate money to the stranger, but instead **donated \$100 to his close friend** to help with the cost of their home's damage.

Experiment 1

Impartial actor helps:



Michael decided not to donate money to his close friend, but instead **donated \$100 to the stranger** to help with the cost of their home's damage.

Partial actor helps:



Michael decided not to donate money to the stranger, but instead **donated \$100 to his close friend** to help with the cost of their home's damage.

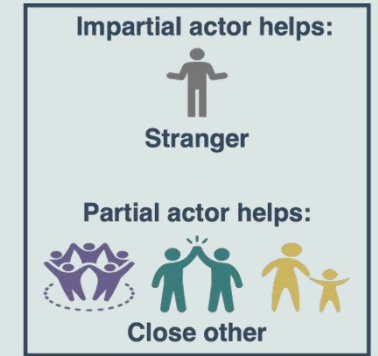
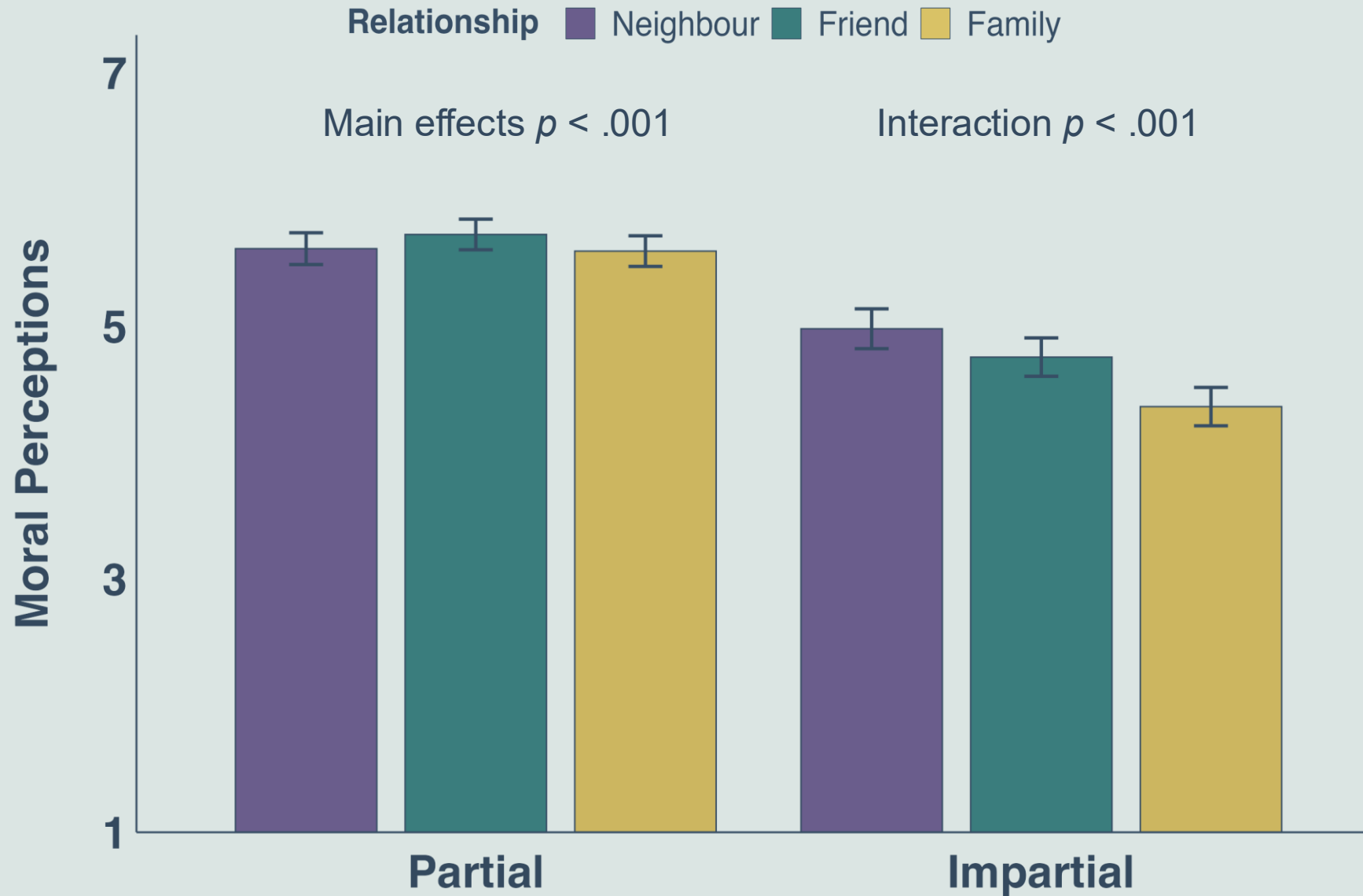
Please judge Michael on each of the dimensions listed below:

Immoral to moral

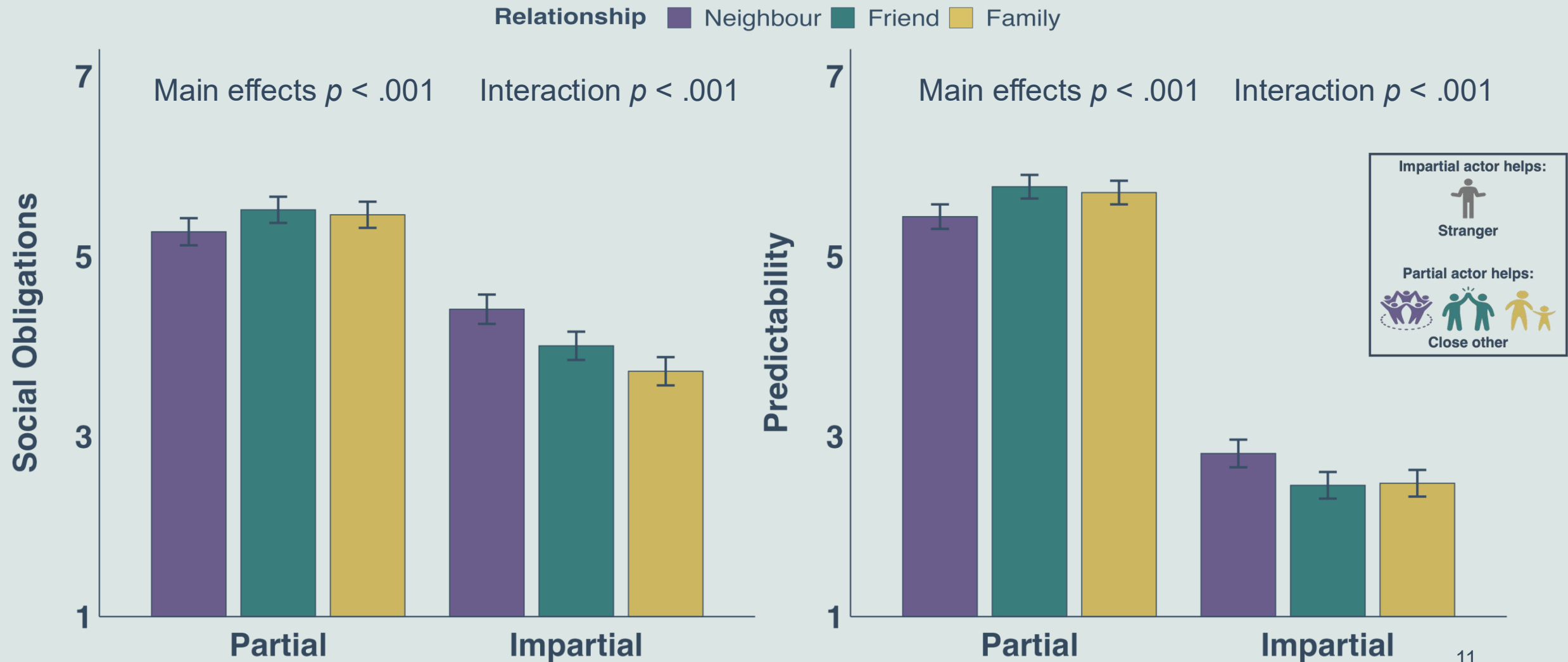
Completely violated obligations to completely fulfilled obligations

Unpredictable to predictable

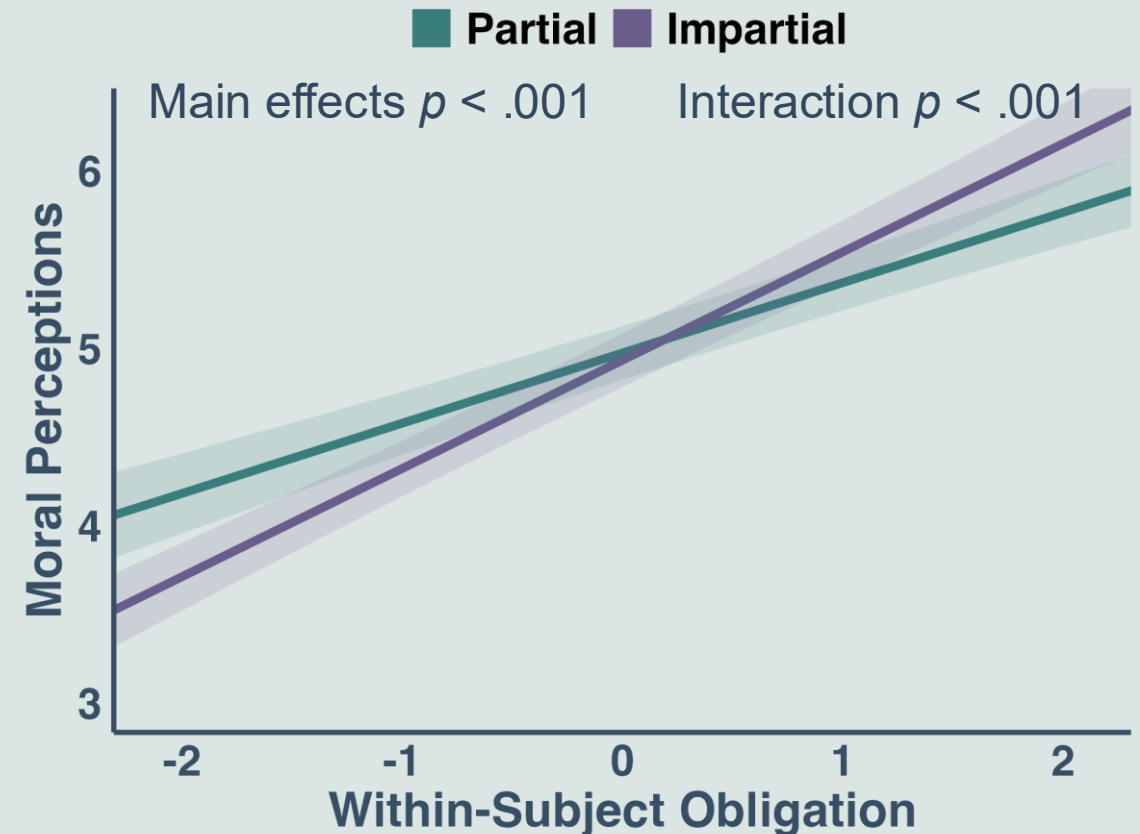
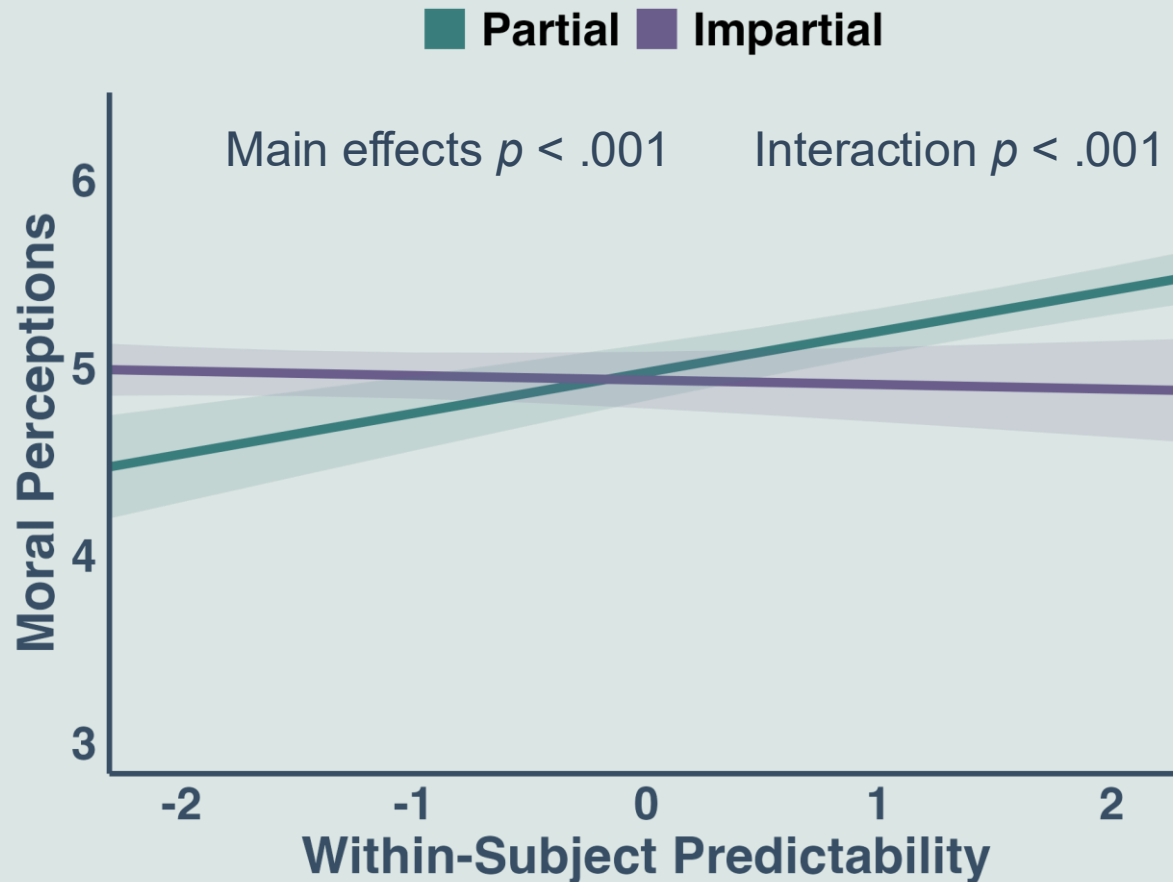
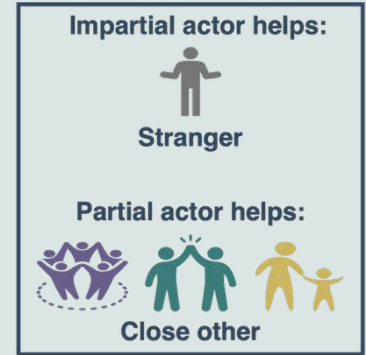
Impartial actors are judged as less moral



Impartial actors are judged as failing obligations and less predictable



Do perceptions of predictability and social obligations influence moral evaluations?



Experiment 2

Do people's own helping decisions reflect this moral preference for partiality?

Does social visibility matter — are people more partial when others are watching?



Two Lawyers Conversing. Honoré Daumier (1808)

Experiment 2



N = 391 (MTurk sample)

- 53 % female
- $M_{age} = 39.55$

... people were using “Go Fund Me” to ask for donations to help pay for flood damage to their homes after a strong thunderstorm. He did not recognize one of the people; he was a stranger. However, he did recognize the other person; he was one of Michael's **close friends**.

Relationship closeness as
between-subject
manipulation:



Neighbour



Close friend



Cousin

Experiment 2

You learn that the **thunderstorm** damaged the **stranger's** home more **severely** compared to the home of your uncle. Thus, the stranger will require significantly more money to fix the damage done to their home.



If you were in Michael's position, who would you give your donation to, your **close friend** or a **stranger**?

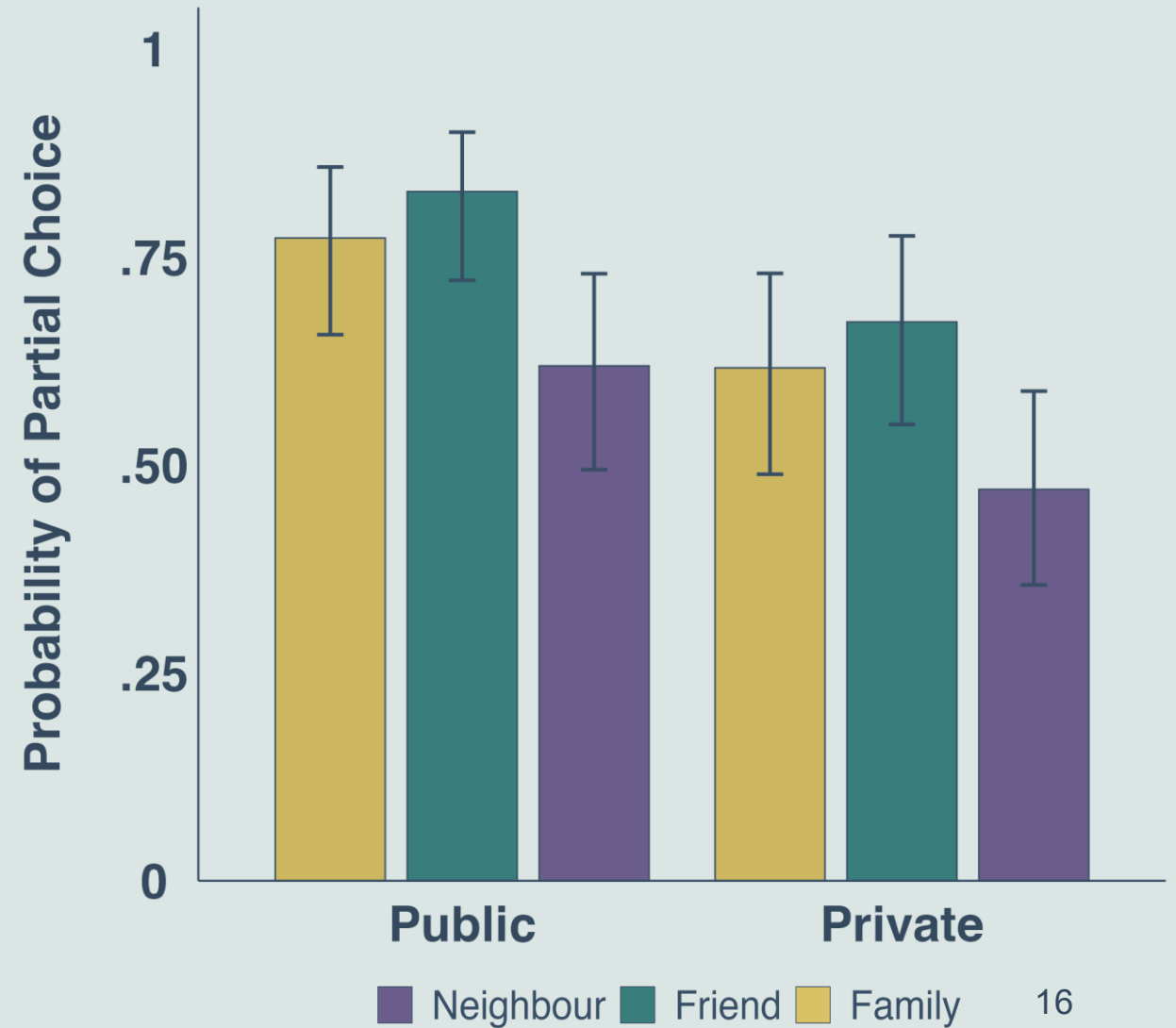


Keep in mind that your donation will be kept **anonymous** / **public** online. Therefore, nobody, including your close friend, will know how you decided to act.

Experiment 2 - Results

65.7% of participants chose to donate to a close other when stranger in more need, $X^2(1) = 42.04, p < .001$.

Partiality preference is weaker for neighbours compared to friends ($p = .002$) and family ($p = .020$).



Conclusions

A **strong moral norm for partiality** is reflected **both** in people's **own** helping decisions and **third-party evaluations** of others

This norm for partiality is moderated by **relationships closeness**

Moral evaluations of partial actors are influenced by **perceived fulfillment of obligations** and **predictability**

Partial actions in close relationships may partly be driven by **impression management**

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